

SoundMAX, too, features intelligent jack sensing, as well as a user interface. The AudioESP (Audio Enumeration and Sensing Process) feature of SoundMAX is an advanced jack-sensing and enumeration feature that eliminates the common connectivity problems users face when trying to match audio peripherals to their PC's I/O jacks. AudioESP notifies users of erroneously connected audio peripherals, guiding them through the process of connecting peripherals to the correct jacks. SoundMAX also offers a "virtual dashboard" that allows users to easily manage audio-related controls. In addition, it includes enhanced audio Wizards that enable users to set up audio peripherals.

The SoundMAX-class AD1985 audio codec features 6-channel sound output, variable sample rate conversion, and 103 dB output with 94 dB SNR. Acer, Intel, MSI, Gigabyte, and Asus all ship SoundMAX on a lot of their motherboards.

1.1.2 Sound Cards

Creative makes some of the best cards in the market. At the low end of the spectrum are the Sound Blaster Live series. The mid-range sees the Creative Audigy series of cards, and if you want only the best, you have the Creative X-Fi card series, the latest and best.

Live! 24-bit

"A good, cheap card" is how the Creative Labs Sound Blaster Live! 24-bit would be best described. Creative calls it "The perfect upgrade from basic motherboard audio for enhanced music, movies, and gaming." Sound Blaster Live! 24-bit supports up to 7.1 surround, and features Creative's EAX Advanced HD technology. EAX essentially allows you to enhance your music with features including Bass Boost, a multi-band graphic equaliser, "audio clean-up," and so on. There's also an external (USB) version available. The non-USB card retails at approximately Rs 2,250.

Audigy

There are several cards in this series, ranging from the Sound Blaster Audigy Value to the Audigy 4 Pro.